against regulations, he said he just could not risk taking a heavy wireless set and battery in addition…. My first reaction was to tell Ram Singh to wait for the next sortie, but Ram Singh quite rightly argued that establishing the set at Tsangdhar was more important as I would be helpless there without communications. In any case, by then the set and the battery had already been strapped on to the outside carrier frame; Ram Singh argued that it would only take a turn-round of 20-25 minutes to drop it at Tsangdhar and return. This made sense, so I got out of the helicopter and allowed Ram Singh to proceed to Tsangdhar.'

Finally, after one and a half hours, HQ 4 Division woke up to the fact that there were two battalions sitting pretty downriver, waiting for the Chinese to regroup and assault them. The order to withdraw was finally given around 11 a.m., after which it took another hour to get organized. As the two battalions left their prepared defences, the Chinese mortar crews got to work.

Meanwhile Prasad was painfully aware that Sehgal had not returned from Tsangdhar. He ordered Squadron Leader A. S. Williams to rescue Sehgal and Ram Singh. Earlier that day Williams had been recalled to Gauhati from Zimithang. Air Vice Marshal Jaswant Singh was waiting for him on the tarmac. The AVM took him to the Dakota that was parked nearby and showed him multiple bullet holes that it had collected earlier over Tsangdhar. He then gave explicit orders not to fly to Tsangdhar as it was already occupied by the Chinese. When Williams told Prasad this, he refused to believe the squadron leader. The need to go to the aid of Sehgal and Ram Singh overrode all other concerns. When Williams went in for a landing approach at Tsangdhar, small arms fire ripped into the cockpit, hitting not only his instrument panel but also the pilot. Somehow, the crippled machine managed to veer away and get past Lumpu before it crashed near Borkungthang. Williams then returned to Zimithang and reported to Prasad that Tsangdhar was crawling with Chinese troops.

It was bad enough that 7 Brigade had disintegrated on his watch in a matter of hours, there was now a desperate need for the GOC to fall back on Tawang and take charge as it was obvious by then that the Chinese were building up for an attack on Bum-la as well.

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